ACTION TRIGGERS · TRANSPORT, LOGISTICS & SUPPLY CHAINS · 16 OCTOBER 2026

War-Risk Insurers Will Decide Gulf Shipping While Suez Freight Rates Keep Falling

Freight costs are splitting by route: the war premium is leaving the Suez lanes as carriers return, while in the Gulf insurers' willingness to cover ships now decides whether goods move. The 2027 freight tenders now being signed lock in one view or the other.

Produced using **Shaping Tomorrow's six-stage process for converting external change into decision-ready intelligence**.
Scanned and filtered by AI. **Stress-tested and judged by humans**.

How long you have to get ready

The five actions below, from today to the moment each falls due. Select a pill to see what would change it, or a number to go to the action.

Now

Now to Dec 2026	Jan–Mar 2027	Apr–Jun 2027
IMMEDIATE	NEXT QUARTER	NEXT PLANNING CYCLE

1 Tender 2027 ocean freight on short, index-linked terms, priced lane by lane.

Head of procurement, with the head of logistics

DECIDE

- 9 Nov: last alliance back at Suez
- 30 Nov: 2027 tenders out

4 Budget carbon costs to 2030 twice: under Europe's rules alone, and under a global price.

Fleet, fuel and freight procurement leads

PREPARE

- 4 Dec: vote on global shipping carbon price

2 Set a contingency for Gulf calls that starts the day war-risk cover is withdrawn.

Chief operating officer, with the insurance buyer

PREPARE

- 31 Mar: contingency in place

3 Count dwell time, storage and stock-holding in the landed cost of every lane.

Supply-chain finance lead

PREPARE

5 Track driverless corridors through the production and permit gates, and plan for retiring drivers first.

Head of road transport, with HR

MONITOR

- 31 Mar: driver plans due

time to get ready · key date · DECIDE act now · PREPARE get ready to act · MONITOR watch it

Early warnings

Signals the portfolio surfaced before consensus formed, in the order they hardened.

LEAD TIME 6 DAYS AHEAD · SIGNAL SCAN · CHANGE TRACKER · DECISION INTELLIGENCE

Freight contracts signed this quarter could pay a Cape-route premium on ships already back in Suez.

INITIAL SIGNAL

We identified that carriers quoting crisis-level rates into 2027 tenders were restoring the Suez routings that remove the basis for those rates, with 9% fleet growth landing behind them.

NOW EVIDENT

- **Routes**: 140 ships, just over 2m TEU, have switched back from the Cape of Good Hope since May, and Suez transits in week 39 ran 68% above a year earlier.
- **Rates**: Asia-Europe spot rates have fallen for 12 consecutive weeks, while transpacific spot stood 344% and 335% above its 28 February level on 1 October.
- **Supply**: BIMCO expects the fleet to grow 9% in 2027 on an orderbook of more than 14 million TEU, about 42% of today's fleet.

LAST ALLIANCE DUE AT SUEZ **9 November 2026**

2027 TENDERS **by end of November 2026**

DECIDE

Procurement heads should price 2027 ocean freight off the falling Suez lanes, not the October peak.

LEAD TIME 6 DAYS AHEAD | SIGNAL SCAN | CHANGE TRACKER

Gulf loadings could stop the day insurers withdraw cover, even while the channel stays open.

INITIAL SIGNAL

We flagged that Hormuz flows remained severely constrained, and named a regular carrier service through the strait as the test that the last detour premium had gone.

NOW EVIDENT

- **Attacks**: 12 attacks in the week to 7 October, with a ship struck nearly every day this month.
- **Cover**: war-risk premiums jumped from between 1% and 3% of hull value to between 7.5% and 10% within weeks, and Marsh warned the market could pull back on Gulf cover.
- **Flows**: daily transits fell from over 130 to 10 in July, and oil now moves through a shuttle system that Lloyd's List does not read as a sustainable new normal.

WILD-CARD LIKELIHOOD **5% to 30% by 2027**

PREPARE

Supply-chain risk owners should treat insurance cover, not the channel, as the point of failure for Gulf calls.

LEAD TIME 3 DAYS AHEAD | DECISION INTELLIGENCE | CHANGE TRACKER

Disruption elsewhere will land on European ports with no spare room until new terminals open.

INITIAL SIGNAL

We identified that the savings from cheaper freight were leaking into ports and warehouses, and that terminals earn more from storage when containers wait.

NOW EVIDENT

- **Rotterdam**: transhipment fell 20% in the first half for lack of terminal capacity, while the Hormuz closure lifted its oil and oil-product throughput by 4.7%.
- **Yards**: Rotterdam and Antwerp yards regularly run above 90% full, and only 28% of sailings from North Europe to the US East Coast arrived on time in July.
- **Holding stock**: the US index for the cost of holding stock reached 78.6 in August, its fourth-highest reading in two years.

NEW ROTTERDAM CAPACITY **from the end of 2026**

PREPARE

Finance and logistics teams should measure every freight saving net of dwell, storage and stock-holding costs.

LEAD TIME 3 DAYS AHEAD | DECISION INTELLIGENCE | CHANGE TRACKER

Airlines may meet their first compulsory offset bill in a credit market a fraction of the size the rule assumes.

INITIAL SIGNAL

We identified that the UN's offsetting scheme for airlines turns compulsory in 2027 with too few eligible credits, while Europe's own fuel mandate is being met.

NOW EVIDENT

- **Credits**: about 32 million tonnes of eligible credits exist, against up to 236 million units IATA estimates the first phase needs.
- **Next phase**: the phase that turns compulsory in January 2027 is estimated to need 880 to 1,350 million tonnes by 2035.
- **Fuel**: Europe's sustainable aviation fuel mandate is being met, at 2.8% of fuel at EU airports in 2025.

COMPULSORY PHASE **January 2027**

PREPARE

Airlines and air-freight buyers should price offset scarcity into 2027 contracts and compare it with fuel blending.

Assumptions that have shifted

Cycle-over-cycle assumption changes, in decreasing order of strategic weight.

SHIFT 1 OF 4 SPLIT

The war premium in freight rates is temporary, and carriers are removing it

PRIOR CYCLE HELD

The cycle's opening scan held that the gap between spot rates and the correction floor "is a war premium whose causes the carriers themselves are removing".

THIS CYCLE READS

True for the Suez lanes and false for the Gulf. Asia-Europe rates have fallen for 12 weeks as ships return, while Hormuz war-risk cover rose to 7.5% to 10% of hull value and strikes came near daily.

FORWARD THESIS

Price the two premiums separately: index the Suez lanes and hold route options for Gulf calls. The tripwire is **a confirmed attack on a containership in the Red Sea corridor**, which would join them again.

SHIFT 2 OF 4 HOLDING

Ships will stay on the Suez route through the 2027 contract round

PRIOR CYCLE HELD

The opening briefing named its own weakest point: "The weakest assumption is that the return to Suez holds."

THIS CYCLE READS

It held its first test. Hormuz attacks pushed Gulf oil and some container services toward Suez and the Cape rather than away from Suez, and Suez transits in week 39 ran 68% above a year earlier.

FORWARD THESIS

Keep the buyer's-market reading for Asia-Europe lanes. The tripwire is **the Premier Alliance's first returning Asia-North Europe sailing transiting Suez on schedule on 9 November 2026**.

SHIFT 3 OF 4 WEAKENED

The global carbon price for shipping has stalled, so Europe's rules set the cost

PRIOR CYCLE HELD

After talks drew a blank for the third meeting in a row, the opening briefing advised readers to "treat a global price as an upside scenario rather than a plan".

THIS CYCLE READS

The deal is contested rather than stalled. Two thirds of the member states that took the floor in September backed pricing, a US-led group is working the procedure, and adoption now has a date in the resumed session on 4 December.

FORWARD THESIS

Budget on Europe's rules, with a second budget ready for a global price. The tripwire is **adoption, or another deferral, at the resumed session on 4 December 2026**.

SHIFT 4 OF 4 SPLIT

Regulators decide how fast driverless trucks spread

PRIOR CYCLE HELD

The opening briefing found driverless trucks carrying paying freight "on very few roads and on thin legal footing", and named US, German and Chinese authorities as the deciders.

THIS CYCLE READS

Both readings hold, in different places. On Aurora's ten Sun Belt routes the limit is now how fast trucks can be built, while elsewhere permits still decide: about 45 trucks run under a contested US waiver, and Germany's first cabless truck runs at 25 km/h behind an escort.

FORWARD THESIS

Treat production and permits as separate gates. The tripwire is **the US decision on Aurora's five-year exemption**.

Actions triggered

Each trigger names why it activates now, why it matters, the recommended actions, the primary decision owner, the decision window, and the conditions under which the recommendation should be reviewed.

DECIDE ACTION 1 SIGNAL SCAN CHANGE TRACKER DECISION INTELLIGENCE

Tender 2027 ocean freight on short, index-linked terms, priced lane by lane.

TRIGGER CONDITION

This recommendation has been activated because 2027 tenders are being quoted while transpacific spot rates sit more than four times their 28 February level, because Asia-Europe rates have fallen for 12 straight weeks as ships return to Suez, and because the US port-fee pause on China-built ships lapses on 9 November with no extension published.

PRIMARY DECISION OWNER **Head of procurement, with the head of logistics**

DECISION WINDOW IMMEDIATE **tenders out by end of November 2026**

WHY THIS NOW MATTERS

A twelve-month rate signed at the war baseline is itself the exposure, because capacity grows 9% in 2027 while demand grows 4.5% at most.

RECOMMENDED ACTIONS

- **Immediate:** issue 2027 tenders with shorter tenors and rates linked to a published index, and split awards across carriers.
- **Immediate:** ask each carrier how its 2027 rate changes if US port fees on China-built ships return after 9 November.
- **Next quarter:** price Suez, Cape and rail routings as named options for time-critical cargo.

REVIEW CONDITIONS

SCALE BACK If the US extends the port-fee pause before 9 November, drop the port-fee question from tenders and keep the rest.

SCALE BACK If a confirmed attack on a containership in the Red Sea corridor sends named Asia-Europe loops back to the Cape, keep index-linked terms but stop pricing tenders off a falling Asia-Europe rate.

STAND DOWN If Asia-North Europe spot holds at or above about $3,800 per FEU through the first quarter of 2027, return to the usual mix of fixed and indexed terms at the next tender.

PREPARE ACTION 2 SIGNAL SCAN CHANGE TRACKER

Set a contingency for Gulf calls that starts the day war-risk cover is withdrawn.

TRIGGER CONDITION

This recommendation has been activated because a ship has been struck in the Strait of Hormuz nearly every day this month, because war-risk premiums rose from between 1% and 3% of hull value to between 7.5% and 10% within weeks, and because the oil still moving depends on a shuttle system that needs cover to run.

PRIMARY DECISION OWNER **Chief operating officer, with the insurance buyer**

DECISION WINDOW NEXT QUARTER **plan in place by 31 March 2027**

WHY THIS NOW MATTERS

A premium can be paid but a withdrawal cannot, so the exposure for Gulf-linked supply is a stoppage lasting weeks rather than a higher bill.

RECOMMENDED ACTIONS

- **Immediate:** list every flow that loads in or calls at the Gulf, including fuel and chemical inputs, and who insures each leg.
- **Next quarter:** agree alternative loading points, buffer stock levels and contract terms that apply if cover is refused.
- **Follow-on:** check whether the southern Red Sea needs the same plan, since cover there repriced within days in July.

REVIEW CONDITIONS

RAISE TO DECIDE If underwriters refuse spot cover for Gulf calls, or shuttle transfers halt, activate the contingency and move buffer stock that week.

SCALE BACK If no ship is struck in the strait for four consecutive weeks while premiums stay high, keep the plan but pause the buffer-stock build.

STAND DOWN If a mainline carrier publishes a regular Gulf service through the Strait of Hormuz, retire the contingency and return Gulf calls to normal planning.

PREPARE ACTION 3 DECISION INTELLIGENCE CHANGE TRACKER

Count dwell time, storage and stock-holding in the landed cost of every lane.

TRIGGER CONDITION

This recommendation has been activated because Rotterdam and Antwerp yards regularly run above 90% full, because Rotterdam lost 20% of its transhipment in the first half for lack of terminal capacity, and because terminals earn more from storage when containers wait.

PRIMARY DECISION OWNER **Supply-chain finance lead**

DECISION WINDOW NEXT PLANNING CYCLE **before 2027 budgets are signed off**

WHY THIS NOW MATTERS

A freight saving that reappears as storage fees and stock-holding still reaches the profit and loss account, so the rate alone overstates what cheaper freight is worth.

RECOMMENDED ACTIONS

- **Immediate:** add dwell time, storage fees and holding costs to the landed-cost model for each lane.
- **Next quarter:** treat the choice of port and stock level as part of the 2027 freight award.

REVIEW CONDITIONS

RAISE TO DECIDE If storage charges on a main European lane rise while its ocean rate falls, move that lane's 2027 award to a less congested port.

STAND DOWN If Rotterdam's new terminal capacity opens from the end of 2026 and its transhipment recovers, return European lanes to rate-led freight budgets.

PREPARE ACTION 4 CHANGE TRACKER DECISION INTELLIGENCE

Budget carbon costs to 2030 twice: under Europe's rules alone, and under a global price.

TRIGGER CONDITION

This recommendation has been activated because shipping's global carbon price returns to an adoption vote on 4 December with two thirds of the member states that spoke in support, because Europe proposes extending its carbon price to ships of 400 to 5,000 gross tonnes, and because airline offsetting turns compulsory in January 2027 with eligible credits scarce.

PRIMARY DECISION OWNER **Fleet, fuel and freight procurement leads**

DECISION WINDOW IMMEDIATE **by 4 December 2026**

WHY THIS NOW MATTERS

The vote decides whether carbon costs follow one price or the route and destination, which changes fleet, fuel and contract choices made this winter.

RECOMMENDED ACTIONS

- **Immediate:** model carbon costs to 2030 under Europe's rules alone and under a global price, ship by ship and lane by lane.
- **Next quarter:** compare the cost of buying eligible aviation offsets early with blending sustainable fuel.
- **Follow-on:** rerun the model after the 4 December session and adjust surcharges and fuel orders.

REVIEW CONDITIONS

RAISE TO DECIDE If the resumed session adopts the global price on 4 December, commit fleet and fuel plans to the global case and plan the overlap with Europe's rules.

SCALE BACK If adoption is deferred again without a vote, drop the global branch from 2027 budgets and plan on Europe's rules.

RAISE TO DECIDE If eligible aviation credits are still below a third of the first phase's estimated need when January 2027 opens, lock in 2027 offset purchases or fuel contracts.

MONITOR ACTION 5 DECISION INTELLIGENCE CHANGE TRACKER

Track driverless corridors through the production and permit gates, and plan for retiring drivers first.

TRIGGER CONDITION

This recommendation has been activated because Aurora's second-generation trucks run paid freight on ten Sun Belt routes, because only about 45 driverless trucks run under a contested US waiver, and because around 660,500 European truck drivers are expected to retire by 2030.

PRIMARY DECISION OWNER Head of road transport, with HR

DECISION WINDOW MONITOR ONLY driver plans by March 2027

WHY THIS NOW MATTERS

Driverless capacity arrives corridor by corridor while the driver gap widens everywhere, so recruitment is the decision and automation is the watch.

RECOMMENDED ACTIONS

- **Immediate:** set driver recruitment and pay plans for 2027 to 2030.
- **Follow-on:** review driverless pilots when the US five-year exemption is decided or Roush reaches its 1,000-truck run-rate.

REVIEW CONDITIONS

RAISE TO PREPARE If Roush reaches its 1,000-truck annual run-rate and a major carrier converts a full lane to driverless, start a pilot on the matching corridor.

RAISE TO PREPARE If the US grants Aurora's five-year exemption, plan which US lanes could take driverless capacity in 2027.

STAND DOWN If a court blocks the US waivers, pause driverless planning and keep the focus on recruitment.

IF YOU ACT ON ONE THING

Tender 2027 ocean freight on short, index-linked terms priced lane by lane, because a year-long rate signed at today's war baseline is itself the exposure.

DRAWING ON



Signal Scan · Change Tracker · Decision Intelligence

Each bone groups the deliverables by what they added, with the oldest at the outer end. Hover over any deliverable for its full title.

HOW THIS WAS MADE

The Decision-Grade Intelligence Method

Shaping Tomorrow's six-stage process for converting external change into decision-ready intelligence.

Scan · Filter · Stress-test · Judge · Trigger · Actionable Intelligence

See full methodology → · How we verify → · Track record →

This briefing is not another report. It is the synthesis produced after continuously monitoring signals, tracking change, testing assumptions and updating scenarios throughout the cycle on **Transport, Logistics & Supply Chains**. Its purpose is to identify the points at which accumulated evidence has become decision-changing: the early warnings the work caught before consensus formed, the assumptions that have shifted between cycles, and the actions now decision-shaped enough to act on. Continuous intelligence on this topic is available as a Single-Topic or Multi-Topic programme.

Discuss a Tailored Programme